

COVID-19 UPDATE FROM THE MINNESOTA CONFERENCE OF THE UNITED METHODIST CHURCH

In response to the COVID-19 pandemic, Governor Tim Walz issued a “stay at home” executive order for Minnesota that will be in effect from 11:59 p.m., Friday, March 27 to Monday, May 4. This critical time is to ensure the government can secure the necessary equipment and hospitals can build up capacity to care for the critically ill. If we do this now, we will save lives.

Faith leaders are listed as an exemption to the governor’s order *in order to perform the absolutely critical and necessary components of their work*. What does that mean? “Faith leaders and workers” includes officials, workers, and leaders in houses of worship and other places of religious expression or fellowship, wherever their services may be needed. This category also includes workers necessary to plan, record, and distribute online or broadcast content to community members.

What does this executive order mean for churches?

- Churches should not have in-person worship.
- Pastoral care visits should be done by phone or online.
- Staff, leadership team, ministry team, youth group, and other group meetings should be done virtually.
- Church volunteers should stop activities that require them to leave their homes.
- Having a few people record or live stream worship from your church sanctuary is permitted, as long as they follow social distancing guidelines and that the number of people does not exceed 10.
- Clergy can leave their homes to do essential work that can’t be done remotely. However, they should remain at home and connect with people virtually whenever possible.

This executive order means we need to stay at home as much as we possibly can. Closely adhering to this executive order is not only about keeping church members and staff safe but also modeling within and for our faith communities the critical behaviors needed to minimize the spread of coronavirus. We have long said that the church is not a building but a people. Now is when we get to put that to the test.

Think about Jesus being led into the wilderness after his baptism; 40 days he was there. He probably would have loved to leave the wilderness and get on with life. But he was called to stay put, and staying put in the wilderness meant wrestling down some temptations: I just need to go run this one errand, I am healthy, it won’t hurt anyone, my work is so important, I am essential, I am the exception to the rule, it all depends on me. Do any of those sound familiar?

Jesus was shaped in the wilderness. Wilderness time strengthened his inner character and resolve, and it allowed him to live and lead in ways that were deeply centered and focused on the kingdom of God. It was not an easy time. He came out exhausted and famished. But he made it through.

We are invited to stay at home right smack dab in the middle of Lent. Wilderness. It is not forever. It is for a season. So how can we see this season as a forming and shaping time for whatever is coming next? It will be hard and require a lot of us, but we are not alone and without resources. We are the people of resurrection. We know who God is and what God can do.